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Introduction & Use of Acronyms in Construction

Construction projects involve a wide range of materials, organizations, codes and units. Because repeating long names slows communication, practitioners rely on acronyms and abbreviations. Many terms have very specific meanings (for example, **MSF** means *thousand square feet* and **MBF** means *thousand board feet*). Others identify composite wood products (e.g., **LVL** refers to *laminated-veneer lumber*) or large organisations (e.g., **OSHA** means *Occupational Safety and Health Administration*, a U.S. workplace-safety agency). This glossary collects common industry acronyms used by Builders FirstSource (BFS) and its customers, summarises their meanings and provides context.

Table: Acronym | Full Term | Definition | Context / Use

Note: Some acronyms are similar—see the disambiguation section for reasoning on differences.

Acronym	Full term	Definition (concise)	Context / Use (concise)
BFS	Builders FirstSource	Building-products and components distributor trading as BLDR on NYSE; abbreviation used internally for the company.	Corporate identifier.
EWP	Engineered wood product	Composite wood member made from reconstituted wood and adhesives; designed for specific structural characteristics and includes products such as LVL and I-joists ¹ .	Structural members used in framing and roof/floor systems.
I-joist	(Engineered) I-shaped joist	Engineered wood joist with top and bottom flanges joined by a vertical web; offers stiffness, light weight and long spans ² .	Floor and roof framing.
LVL	Laminated-veneer lumber	Structural composite lumber made by bonding thin wood veneers with grain parallel; billets are sawn to size and used as beams, headers and rafters ³ .	Beams, headers, rim boards and structural framing.

Acronym	Full term	Definition (concise)	Context / Use (concise)
PSL	Parallel-strand lumber	Structural composite lumber made by laying long wood strands in parallel and bonding them with adhesives; provides high bending strength for long-span beams and columns ⁴ .	Long beams, columns, headers.
LSL	Laminated-strand lumber	Structural composite lumber made from flaked wood strands (long length-to-thickness ratio) bonded with adhesives; used for headers, beams, wall studs and rim boards ⁵ .	Structural framing and millwork.
OSL	Oriented-strand lumber	Structural composite lumber made from shorter flaked wood strands (length-to-thickness ≈ 75) bonded with adhesive ⁶ .	Studs, millwork and small structural members.
SCL	Structural composite lumber	Family of engineered lumber products formed by layering veneers, strands or flakes with adhesive into billets; grain runs mostly in the same direction and products offer uniform strength ⁷ .	Umbrella term covering LVL, PSL, LSL and OSL.
OSB	Oriented-strand board	Structural wood panel manufactured from cross-oriented wood strands and waterproof adhesive; strong, dimensionally stable and produced in large panels ⁸ .	Sheathing, subfloors and roof panels.
CLT	Cross-laminated timber	Prefabricated engineered wood product consisting of at least three layers of lumber arranged crosswise and bonded with structural adhesive ⁹ .	Floor, wall and roof panels in mass-timber buildings.
HDO	High-density overlay plywood	Exterior plywood overlaid with resin-impregnated fiber faces; has more resin than MDO and provides a durable, smooth surface for demanding applications ¹⁰ .	Concrete form panels and industrial finishes.
MDO	Medium-density overlay plywood	Plywood with resin-impregnated fiber faces; combines strength of exterior plywood with a paintable surface ¹⁰ .	Concrete formwork, sign boards and general construction.

Acronym	Full term	Definition (concise)	Context / Use (concise)
MDF	Medium-density fiberboard	Engineered wood product made by compressing hardwood or softwood fibers with resin and wax under high temperature and pressure; yields a smooth, paint-friendly surface and resists cracking ¹¹ .	Millwork, cabinetry and interior trim.
SPF	Spruce-Pine-Fir (species group)	Species grouping of commercial softwoods; denotes lumber from spruce, pine and fir trees grown in Canada; similar group harvested in USA is labelled SPF's (with an "s") ¹² ¹³ .	Light framing lumber for housing and manufactured components.
SYP	Southern yellow pine	Group of four pine species—loblolly, longleaf, shortleaf and slash pine—grown mainly in the American Southeast; valued for density and strength ¹⁴ .	Strong, nail-holding framing lumber and decking.
MSR	Machine stress-rated lumber	Lumber whose modulus of elasticity is measured by mechanical stress-rating equipment; each piece is marked to indicate its stiffness ¹⁵ .	Structural lumber requiring predictable strength (e.g., trusses).
MSF	Thousand square feet	Measurement unit equal to 1,000 square feet; "M" represents 1,000 in Roman numerals ¹⁶ .	Used to quote panel quantities or sheet goods.
MLF	Thousand linear feet	Measurement unit equal to 1,000 linear feet ¹⁶ .	Used for trim, moulding or piping.
MBF	Thousand board feet	Volume unit equal to 1,000 board feet (a board foot is a volume of a board 1 ft long × 1 ft wide × 1 in thick) ¹⁷ .	Lumber and timber volume for pricing and estimates.
MBH	Thousand BTU per hour	Unit representing 1,000 British thermal units per hour; listed in unit abbreviations ¹⁸ .	Heating equipment capacity ratings.
MCF	Thousand cubic feet	Volume unit equal to 1,000 cubic feet ¹⁸ .	Gas and wood product volumes.
PPE	Personal protective equipment	Equipment worn to minimize exposure to hazards causing injuries or illnesses; includes gloves, goggles, safety shoes, earplugs, hard hats, respirators and specialized clothing ¹⁹ .	Worker safety in construction and manufacturing.

Acronym	Full term	Definition (concise)	Context / Use (concise)
SDS	Safety data sheet	Document providing information on chemical hazards and safe handling; formerly called MSDS. SDSs are standardized under the Globally Harmonized System and are required for each hazardous substance ²⁰ .	Hazard communication and chemical safety.
PVA	Polyvinyl acetate (glue)	Common wood adhesive; carpenters prefer PVA glue because it is easy to use, dries quickly and forms a bond that can be stronger than the wood itself ²¹ .	Wood bonding, cabinetry and furniture fabrication.
HVAC	Heating, ventilation and air conditioning	Systems providing thermal comfort by heating or cooling spaces, moving air between indoor/outdoor areas and improving indoor air quality ²² .	Mechanical systems in buildings.
MEP	Mechanical, electrical and plumbing	Integrated building systems providing climate control, power distribution, water supply and waste removal; form the backbone of a building's operational infrastructure ²³ .	Design and coordination of building services.
BIM	Building information modeling	Holistic process of creating and managing information for a built asset; uses an intelligent digital model and cloud platform to represent the building from planning through operations ²⁴ .	Collaborative design, construction and asset management.
AWP	Advanced work packaging	Construction-driven planning framework and Construction Industry Institute best practice that brings construction into planning early; develops detailed work packages to guide field activities ²⁵ .	Planning and execution of capital projects.
GC	General contractor	Construction professional or company that provides all services needed to deliver a project; manages job-site operations, hires subcontractors and bridges communication between the owner, architect and engineers ²⁶ .	Overall project execution on behalf of the owner.
IBC	International Building Code	Comprehensive building code published by the International Code Council; provides design and installation requirements to protect public health and safety, encourages technological advances and references national standards ²⁷ .	Building code used by many U.S. jurisdictions.

Acronym	Full term	Definition (concise)	Context / Use (concise)
IRC	International Residential Code	Code addressing design and construction of one- and two-family dwellings and townhouses up to three stories; includes building, energy, plumbing, mechanical and electrical provisions ²⁸ .	Residential building regulations.
OSHA	Occupational Safety and Health Administration	U.S. federal agency whose mission is to assure safe and healthful working conditions by setting and enforcing standards, enforcing anti-retaliation provisions, providing training and collaborating with state programs ²⁹ .	Workplace safety regulation and enforcement.
ACI	American Concrete Institute	Leading authority for developing, distributing and adopting consensus-based standards, technical resources and educational programs for concrete design and construction ³⁰ .	Standards and codes for concrete materials and structures.
AISC	American Institute of Steel Construction	Not-for-profit technical institute supported by the steel industry; partners with the architecture, engineering and construction community to develop safe and efficient steel specifications and codes ³¹ .	Structural steel specifications and market development.
ANSI	American National Standards Institute	Non-governmental, not-for-profit organization coordinating and administering the U.S. voluntary standards and conformity-assessment system; its mission is to enhance global competitiveness and quality of life by promoting voluntary consensus standards ³² .	Oversees standards development (e.g., safety equipment).
NFPA	National Fire Protection Association	Global self-funded nonprofit established in 1896; aims to eliminate deaths, injuries and property loss due to fire and related hazards. NFPA provides over 300 consensus codes and standards, research, education and advocacy ³³ .	Fire and life-safety codes (e.g., NFPA 70® Electrical Code).

Grouped by Domain

Structural & Material Products

These acronyms describe engineered wood products or lumber species. **EWP** is an umbrella term for engineered wood members such as **LVL**, **PSL**, **LSL** and **I-joists** ¹ . **SCL** (structural composite lumber) products are manufactured by layering veneers, strands or flakes in the same grain direction ⁷ . Panel

products include **OSB**, **HDO**, **MDO**, **CLT** and **MDF** ⁸ . Species designations like **SPF** and **SYP** indicate groups of softwood species used for light framing or heavy-duty construction ¹² ¹⁴ .

Measurement Units & Quantities

Units with an “M” prefix represent quantities in thousands (Roman numeral *M* = 1,000). **MBF** means thousand board feet (volume), **MSF** means thousand square feet and **MLF** means thousand linear feet ¹⁷ ¹⁶ . The “B” in **MBH** means British Thermal Units; **MBH** therefore refers to 1,000 BTU/h ¹⁸ . **MCF** stands for thousand cubic feet (volume) ¹⁸ .

Codes & Organizations

Regulatory and standard-setting organizations use acronyms that often appear in specifications. **IBC** and **IRC** are the primary U.S. model codes for commercial and residential construction, respectively ²⁷ ²⁸ . **OSHA** governs workplace safety and health ²⁹ , while **NFPA** develops fire and life-safety codes ³³ . **ACI** and **AISC** publish concrete and steel standards ³⁰ ³¹ . **ANSI** coordinates voluntary consensus standards across industries ³² .

Safety & Administrative Terms

Personal safety acronyms include **PPE** (equipment protecting workers from hazards ¹⁹) and **SDS**, the mandatory document summarising chemical hazards and handling procedures ²⁰ . Safety data sheets replaced the earlier Material Safety Data Sheets (MSDS). **PVA** adhesives provide strong, user-friendly bonds for wood ²¹ , whereas **MSR** lumber is mechanically tested to ensure consistent stiffness ¹⁵ .

Project Planning & Building Systems

In project delivery, **GC** refers to the general contractor managing daily construction activities ²⁶ . **MEP** describes the integrated mechanical, electrical and plumbing systems that make buildings habitable ²³ , while **HVAC** is a subset focusing on heating, ventilation and air conditioning ²² . Digital collaboration uses **BIM**—an intelligent model representing the facility throughout its lifecycle ²⁴ . For industrial projects, **AWP** (advanced work packaging) is a best-practice framework that brings construction considerations into early planning and produces detailed work packages ²⁵ .

Tips on Disambiguation & Common Mistakes

- **MSF vs. MBF vs. MLF:** All three begin with *M* for one-thousand. However, **MSF** measures *area* (square feet), **MLF** measures *length* (linear feet) and **MBF** measures *volume* (board feet). A board foot is a volume of wood 1 ft × 1 ft × 1 in thick ¹⁷ .
- **SPF vs. SPF_s:** SPF stands for spruce-pine-fir lumber produced in Canada. An “s” suffix indicates logs harvested in the USA ¹² . The “s” also denotes a slightly different group of species (SPF excludes Sitka spruce, Norway spruce and red pine but includes alpine fir) ³⁴ .
- **LVL vs. LSL vs. OSL:** All are structural composite lumber. **LVL** is made from continuous veneers and has high strength along the length ³ . **LSL** uses long flaked strands and suits wall studs and headers ⁵ . **OSL** uses shorter flaked strands and is typically used for non-structural members ⁶ .

- **HDO vs. MDO:** Both are plywood panels with resin-impregnated overlays. **HDO** contains more resin and offers a harder surface for concrete forming ¹⁰ ; **MDO** provides a paintable surface for signs and general construction ¹⁰ .
- **EWP vs. SCL:** *Engineered wood product* (EWP) is a broad category of composite wood components (such as LVL, I-joists and CLT). *Structural composite lumber* (SCL) is a sub-category within EWP that uses veneers, strands or flakes oriented in the same direction ⁷ .
- **BIM vs. CAD:** BIM extends beyond 2D computer-aided design by integrating intelligent 3D models with data about materials, scheduling and lifecycle management ²⁴ .

Likely User Questions

- *What does EWP stand for and how is it different from solid lumber?*
- *What's the difference between LVL and LSL?*
- *Is OSB the same as OSL?*
- *What does MBF mean when pricing lumber?*
- *How do MSF and MLF differ?*
- *What species are included in SPF vs. SPF's lumber?*
- *What is a safety data sheet (SDS) and why is it required?*
- *How does AWP improve construction productivity?*
- *What are MEP systems and how do they relate to HVAC?*
- *Why is BIM considered a holistic approach compared to traditional CAD?*

Related Topics / Crosslinks

- **Engineered Wood Products Overview** – deeper dive into LVL, PSL, LSL, OSL and CLT.
- **Building Code Essentials** – summary of IBC and IRC requirements for designers.
- **Project Delivery Methods** – explanation of design-build, design-bid-build and integrated project delivery.
- **Construction Safety** – guide to OSHA regulations, PPE selection and SDS compliance.
- **Digital Construction** – explores BIM, digital twins, and construction management software.

¹ 4 Advantages of Using Engineered Wood Products over Traditional Sawn Lumber | Roseburg
<https://www.roseburg.com/news-product/4-advantages-of-using-engineered-wood-products-over-traditional-sawn-lumber/>

² I-Joists - American Wood Council
<https://awc.org/woodproductdirectory/i-joists/>

³ ⁶ ⁷ Structural Composite Lumber (SCL) - APA – The Engineered Wood Association
<https://www.apawood.org/structural-composite-lumber>

⁴ What is Parallel strand lumber (PSL) & How is it made | naturally:wood
<https://www.naturallywood.com/engineered-wood-products/parallel-strand-lumber-psl/>

⁵ What is Laminated strand lumber (LSL) & How is it made | naturally:wood
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⁸ Oriented Strand Board (OSB) - APA – The Engineered Wood Association
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- 9 What is cross laminated timber (CLT)? - American Wood Council
<https://awc.org/faq/what-is-cross-laminated-timber-clt/>
- 10 Overlaid (HDO/MDO) - APA – The Engineered Wood Association
<https://www.apawood.org/overlaid>
- 11 Everything You Need to Know About MDF Doors | Manhattan Door
<https://www.manhattandoor.com/blog/mdf-doors/>
- 12 13 34 SPFs VS. SPF - Sherwood Lumber
<https://sherwoodlumber.com/spfs-vs-spf/>
- 14 Understanding Southern Yellow Pine - Wood. It's Real.
<https://wooditsreal.com/environmental/understanding-southern-yellow-pine/>
- 15 Machine Stress Rated (MSR) and Machine Evaluated (MEL) Lumber
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- 16 Conversion Tables and Units of Quantity
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- 17 Lumber 101 — Gray Lumber
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- 18 Guide Lines For Using & Interpreting The CTC
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<https://www.luc.edu/environmentalservices/occupationalhealthandsafety/ppe.shtml>
- 20 Safety Data Sheets | Safety Services
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- 21 PVA glue: What you need to know about the best wood glue
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- 22 What is HVAC? | Learn the HVAC Meaning & More | Carrier
<https://www.carrier.com/residential/en/us/glossary/hvac-meaning/>
- 23 MEP Construction Explained: The Role of Mechanical, Electrical, and Plumbing Systems in Building Projects | Procore AU
<https://www.procore.com/en-au/library/mep-construction>
- 24 What Is BIM | Building Information Modeling | Autodesk
<https://www.autodesk.com/solutions/aec/bim>
- 25 The Advanced Work Packaging (AWP) Guide for Construction Planning
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- 26 What Is a General Contractor In Construction? Role & Responsibilities
<https://www.projectmanager.com/blog/construction-general-contractor>
- 27 The International Building Code - ICC
<https://www.iccsafe.org/products-and-services/i-codes/2018-i-codes/ibc/>
- 28 The International Residential Code - ICC
<https://www.iccsafe.org/products-and-services/i-codes/2018-i-codes/irc/>

29 About OSHA | Occupational Safety and Health Administration

<https://www.osha.gov/aboutosha>

30 American Concrete Institute (ACI) - Construction Management

<https://www.boisestate.edu/coen-cm/american-concrete-institute-aci/>

31 About Us | American Institute of Steel Construction

<https://www.aisc.org/about-us/>

32 ANSI Standards | Intertek Inform

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33 About Us | Sparky School House

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